SHOPPAGE v4.0

Zimbabwe Commerce Marketplace and Operating System

Investment-Grade Operating Master | July 2026

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Confidentiality and document status

Confidential operating document. This document is a strategy, operating-model and investment-planning instrument for Shoppage. It is not legal, tax, payments-regulatory or investment advice. All launch actions that involve custody of customer funds, consumer credit, personal-data processing, restricted products, fiscalisation, cross-border payments or statutory representations require written advice from appropriately qualified Zimbabwean advisers and, where relevant, approval from the responsible regulator or licensed partner.

Document status. Version 4.0 replaces the previous Shoppage v3.0 draft as the proposed operating master. It preserves the strongest ideas from the earlier work - shared catalogue, local offer truth, assisted merchant onboarding, market-level activation, compatibility data, canonical links and a first-party commerce graph - but removes unsupported market claims, duplicate “moat” sections, premature plugin expansion and the unresolved contradiction between a referral directory and a checkout-led marketplace.

Binding language. In this document:

- **Decision** means the current operating choice and should not be changed without an explicit decision record.
- **Gate** means a condition that must pass before the next stage begins.
- **Target** means a management objective, not a forecast or investor promise.
- **Hypothesis** means a proposition that must be tested with field evidence.
- **Option** means deliberately deferred scope.

Executive verdict

1. The business Shoppage should actually build

Shoppage should be a **managed, asset-light, Zimbabwe-first multi-vendor marketplace** that owns the digital customer journey while merchants own inventory and licensed partners handle regulated payment and delivery functions.

The platform must own five things from day one: structured product discovery, seller-offer comparison, checkout and order state, customer support and returns orchestration, and first-party evidence of whether orders were accepted and fulfilled. Social media is an acquisition channel. It is not the transaction system. A Facebook post, WhatsApp status or creator video may start demand, but the canonical product, price, seller, order, delivery promise and complaint record must live on Shoppage.

Shoppage is **not**:

- a national directory containing hundreds of thousands of unverified businesses;
- a social-media referral site that sends customers away before checkout;
- a stock-owning Amazon clone in the first two years;
- a courier company, wallet, lender or warehouse operator at launch;
- an agency SaaS, public API marketplace or WordPress-plugin company before the commerce engine works;
- a mass-market national marketplace on launch day.

The core model is one marketplace storefront, one shared master catalogue, multiple seller offers, one order and exception ledger, and one operations console. Seller stores are filtered views of the shared catalogue and offer data; they are not independent websites or databases. Buyers can **Buy Now**, **Reserve and Collect**, **Request a Quote**, or join a **Pre-order / Group Buy** depending on the category and fulfilment risk.

This is the strategic resolution of the earlier contradiction. The prior referral model correctly recognised that national logistics, payment custody and merchant maturity are difficult. The prior checkout model correctly recognised that a true marketplace must own the order, delivery promise, tracking and returns. Version 4.0 combines these into a controlled transaction ladder rather than choosing between “referral only” and “full Amazon on day one.”

2. The launch wedge

The launch should be **Harare-first and cell-based**, with a narrow set of categories in which local stock varies materially, buyers already compare prices through WhatsApp and Facebook, and merchants have enough gross margin to pay for demand.

The recommended launch category family is **Power, Tools and Home Improvement**, but it must be split by transaction type:

Lane	Initial scope	Customer action
Buy Now	Electrical accessories, solar lights, small backup-power items, tools, small appliances, standardised parts	Pay online and receive delivery or pickup
Reserve and Collect	Inverters, batteries, generators, larger appliances and selected tools	Place verified reservation or deposit
Request a Quote	Cement, roofing, timber, plumbing bundles, installations and bulky building materials	Structured quote with response SLA

This avoids the error of forcing one checkout design onto products with radically different logistics, warranty and specification risks. It also creates a realistic path to the user's stated Amazon/Takealot ambition without pretending that a 50kg bag of cement and a phone charger have the same transaction economics.

The first operating cell should cover a tightly managed Harare corridor with real merchant density, courier availability and founder access. Graniteside, Workington, Southerton, Msasa, Gazaland and selected central Harare zones are candidates, but the final two-cell choice must be based on field verification rather than database counts alone.

3. The decisive strategic choices

1. **Marketplace before intelligence.** Commerce events create defensible data. “National intelligence” built mostly from third-party or scraped data is fragile. Price Pulse, Demand Radar and agency analytics become credible after Shoppage has first-party searches, quotes, orders, cancellations and fulfilment records.
2. **Twenty anchor merchants before ten thousand profiles.** A live merchant with accurate stock and a tested fulfilment process is more valuable than hundreds of unclaimed records. The 200,000-company dataset should initially be an internal prospecting and market-mapping asset, not a public inventory claim.
3. **Five thousand accurate offers before one million reference products.** Product breadth without local price, stock and seller accountability creates a misleading catalogue. The master catalogue should grow from merchant-authorised data, manufacturer data with usage rights, and controlled enrichment.
4. **Operations before consumer polish.** The hard product is not the home page. It is seller verification, product matching, order acknowledgement, payment reconciliation, delivery exceptions, cancellation, return, refund and complaint resolution.
5. **Contribution margin before geographic expansion.** Every new category and operating cell must pass a contribution test. National coverage is not a launch feature; it is the result of repeating proven local cells.
6. **Licensed partners before regulated ambition.** Payments, fund custody, lending, insurance and national courier operations should be partner-led until legal and economic evidence justifies a licensed subsidiary or deeper integration.

4. Twelve-month target state

By month 12, the base-case target is:

- 150 to 200 active merchants, of which at least 80 are transaction-active in the previous 30 days;
- 40,000 to 75,000 current seller offers attached to a controlled master catalogue;
- 3,000 to 4,000 completed orders or verified quote/reservation outcomes per month;
- at least two Harare operating cells with stable fulfilment and support;
- seller-caused cancellation below 4%;
- at least 90% on-time delivery or pickup readiness within the promised window;
- 100% payment-to-order reconciliation;
- positive contribution margin before central product and corporate payroll in the core transaction lanes;
- no material unresolved data-rights, consumer-protection or payment-custody breach.

These are management targets, not forecasts. The business must be willing to stop expansion if they are not met.

Part I - Red-team analysis of Shoppage v3.0

5. What the previous model got right

The prior model contained several strong strategic insights.

First, it rejected the empty-marketplace problem. Preloading a controlled master catalogue, merchant prospect list, place taxonomy and local product synonyms can reduce cold-start friction. The principle is sound provided the records are rights-cleared, accurately labelled and never presented as current local stock without merchant confirmation.

Second, it correctly prioritised **branch-level offer freshness**. A marketplace becomes useful when a buyer can distinguish “listed somewhere” from “available from this seller, at this branch, at this price, as of this time.” Freshness should affect ranking, advertising eligibility and buyer confidence.

Third, the earlier work recognised Zimbabwe’s low-data and assisted-onboarding reality. A mobile-first seller workspace, photo and spreadsheet ingestion, voice-note support, manual exception handling and field-assisted activation are more realistic than requiring every merchant to maintain a sophisticated dashboard.

Fourth, it correctly separated the master product from the merchant offer. This is essential. The master product contains stable identity and specification data; the seller offer contains price, currency, stock, location, warranty, lead time and seller-specific terms.

Fifth, it identified compatibility as a strong wedge in power and building categories. Buyers do not merely want “a battery”; they need to know whether a battery, inverter, cable, breaker and panel configuration can work together. A validated compatibility graph can increase conversion and reduce returns.

Sixth, it treated Facebook groups, WhatsApp, creator content and merchant websites as distribution surfaces rather than the platform’s identity layer. Canonical Shoppage links and product records should survive changes in external platforms.

Seventh, it acknowledged that data rights, privacy, security and field economics are launch gates. Those gates remain, but Version 4.0 makes them measurable and assigns owners.

6. What must be discarded

The previous draft cannot function as an operating master in its current form.

6.1 False length and duplicated substance

The file is 37 pages, not the advertised 80-plus pages. Its later “deep dive” sections repeat substantially the same text under different section numbers. This creates the appearance of depth while omitting the promised work on payment settlement, fulfilment, unit economics, competition, technology, risk, roadmap and appendices.

6.2 Strategic ambiguity

The document repeatedly says “referral beats marketplace,” while also proposing checkout, shoppable video, stock truth and fulfilment orchestration. A referral model and a managed marketplace have different legal obligations, product architecture, economics and customer promises. The business cannot price, build or govern itself until that choice is resolved.

Version 4.0 resolves it: **Shoppage is a managed marketplace with multiple transaction lanes.** Referral-only events are a fallback or lead product for categories that cannot yet support controlled checkout.

6.3 Scope explosion

Merchant sites, market digital twins, referral tracking, AI recommendations, trust seals, short video, agency intelligence, plugins, market captains, creator commissions, national data and fulfilment were all treated as simultaneous launch priorities. This is not an MVP; it is several companies.

The launch product should contain only:

- shopper search and product pages;
- shared catalogue and seller offers;
- cart or structured request flow;
- payment status;
- vendor order acknowledgement;
- delivery or pickup tracking;
- returns and refunds;
- seller onboarding and admin exception queues;
- core trust and audit controls.

Everything else must justify itself against this core.

6.4 Unsupported data certainty

The earlier draft treats large company, group and product datasets as owned, accurate and immediately usable. Each dataset may contain duplicates, stale records, copyrighted images, restricted terms, inferred classifications or data collected under conditions that do not permit public indexing or AI use.

Data volume is not a moat until Shoppage can prove:

- legal or contractual usage rights;

- provenance and collection date;
- entity resolution quality;
- correction and suppression mechanisms;
- merchant consent for current offers;
- measurable use in conversion or operations.

6.5 Weak economics

A $19 merchant subscription cannot support a national commerce operation by itself. The previous document did not calculate payment costs, refunds, chargebacks, delivery support, field onboarding, seller support, moderation, cloud infrastructure, customer service or reconciliation labour. It also did not state the order volume required to cover payroll.

Version 4.0 uses a blended model: transaction service fees, merchant subscription, transparent promotion, fulfilment margin, onboarding services and later first-party intelligence. It also distinguishes gross revenue from pass-through payment and delivery costs.

6.6 Premature “moats”

A feature is not a moat. A badge, plugin, short-video carousel or market page can be copied. Defensibility comes from hard-to-recreate operating assets: verified seller performance history, current branch offers, product matching, compatibility evidence, low-cost onboarding, dense pickup and delivery relationships, trusted dispute handling and repeat buyer behaviour.

6.7 Regulatory under-specification

The earlier model correctly mentioned privacy and payment licensing but did not translate them into an actionable compliance programme. Zimbabwe’s data-controller licensing rules, breach deadlines, consumer-protection obligations, fiscalisation requirements, payment-provider contracts and marketplace terms require named workstreams, evidence and budgets.

7. The revised opportunity statement

Zimbabwe does not need another directory or generic classifieds site. It needs a transaction system that converts fragmented local supply into reliable, searchable and accountable commerce.

The opportunity exists because current alternatives are incomplete:

- social groups and WhatsApp have liquidity but weak structure, weak verification and no standard order state;
- classifieds provide broad listings and seller contact but generally leave the contract and fulfilment directly between buyer and seller;
- individual retailer sites offer controlled checkout but limited cross-merchant comparison and inconsistent delivery coverage;
- vertical diaspora grocery and gifting services solve a narrow use case but do not provide an open merchant marketplace;
- formal chains cannot represent the breadth, price diversity and geographic presence of Zimbabwe's informal and micro-enterprise base.

The first-ever ZIMSTAT Economic Census identified 204,798 operating establishments and reported that 76.1% were informal. That fact supports an assisted, low-friction merchant model; it does not support indiscriminately publishing 200,000 profiles. The marketplace must make informal supply transactable without falsely representing registration, tax status, warranties or stock.

Part II - Market and customer model

8. Ground truth and design consequences

Zimbabwe's commerce environment requires a model designed around practical constraints rather than imported platform assumptions.

Multi-currency

Prices, supplier costs and customer payment preferences may differ by currency. The platform data model must store the offer currency, settlement currency, displayed conversion basis, timestamp and source. Shoppage should not silently convert prices or present a platform "rate" as official. A seller must explicitly confirm the amount and currency that will be honoured.

Mobile and intermittent connectivity

The storefront must be fast on low-cost Android devices and usable under intermittent data. Critical order status should be available by SMS or WhatsApp notification, but the underlying record must remain on Shoppage. Images should be compressed; video should be optional; seller workflows should support saved drafts and retry queues.

Address and location variability

Street addresses may be inconsistent. The location model should combine city, suburb or industrial area, landmark, map pin, delivery zone and human instructions. A map pin alone is insufficient for a stall in a market or an unnumbered industrial property.

Mixed merchant maturity

Some merchants have ERPs and WooCommerce; many maintain stock in notebooks, spreadsheets or WhatsApp chats. Shoppage therefore needs three onboarding lanes: assisted, self-service bulk import and integrated feed. The first launch cohort should deliberately include merchants from all three lanes to prove the operating model.

Trust and recourse

A buyer's primary question is not whether a seller has a green badge. It is whether the item exists, the price will be honoured, the seller responds, the delivery promise is credible, and there is a clear remedy when something goes wrong. Trust must be represented as specific evidence, not a vague "verified" label.

9. Customer segments

9.1 Local retail buyer

The local buyer wants current price, real stock, nearby fulfilment and a seller who will answer. They are likely to compare across WhatsApp, Facebook, physical shops and Shoppage. The winning proposition is reduced search time and lower risk, not merely more products.

Job to be done: “Help me find the correct item, at a fair current price, from a seller who can fulfil today or within a credible window.”

9.2 Small contractor and tradesperson

Electricians, builders, plumbers, installers and small manufacturers buy repeatedly, care about compatibility and need quotes that can be shared with customers. Their basket may contain several related items and delivery to a job site.

Job to be done: “Turn a specification or bill of quantities into a complete, available and correctly matched order.”

9.3 Diaspora buyer

The diaspora customer pays from outside Zimbabwe for goods delivered to family, a building project or a business. They need recipient confirmation, transparent local delivery, proof of fulfilment and protection against substitution.

Job to be done: “Let me pay remotely and know exactly what was delivered, to whom, and when.”

9.4 Micro and informal merchant

This merchant may not have a website, product feed, tax invoice system or staff dedicated to online sales. They need assisted catalogue creation and immediate evidence that Shoppage produces worthwhile leads or orders.

Job to be done: “Bring me profitable demand without forcing me to become a software administrator.”

9.5 Formal retailer, distributor or manufacturer

This seller has product data and stronger controls but worries about channel conflict, margin disclosure, inventory accuracy and marketplace fees. They need integration, branch-level offers, controlled promotions and useful reporting.

Job to be done: “Give me incremental demand and market visibility without creating operational chaos or destroying price discipline.”

10. Buyer promise

The public promise should be simple:

> ***Find it locally. Compare real offers. Buy with a clear delivery or collection promise.***

Every customer-facing feature must support at least one of four buyer outcomes:

1. **Correctness:** the right product, specification, variant and compatibility.
2. **Availability:** a current offer from a named seller and branch.
3. **Confidence:** seller evidence, order protection and visible terms.
4. **Completion:** payment, delivery or pickup, and a workable remedy.

The platform should never use “available,” “verified,” “guaranteed,” “lowest price” or “delivered by” without defined evidence and responsibility.

11. Merchant promise

The merchant proposition is:

> ***Turn your real stock and capability into orders, not just views.***

The merchant should receive:

- a claimable merchant page and branch profile;
- assisted or bulk catalogue onboarding;
- current-offer publishing and freshness controls;
- order, reservation and quote management;
- delivery or pickup configuration;
- customer messaging without surrendering the canonical order record;
- performance reporting;
- exportable product cards for WhatsApp, Facebook and websites;
- transparent fees and payout reconciliation.

The merchant should not be promised unlimited free leads, instant national reach or a “website replacement.” Shoppage must prove incremental gross profit after fees and operational effort.

12. Competitive position

Alternative	What it does well	Shoppage's differentiation
Facebook and WhatsApp commerce	Existing attention, conversational selling, low friction	Structured catalogue, order state, seller evidence, comparison and recourse
Classifieds platforms	Broad listings, search, strong category familiarity	Managed checkout, shared product identity, fulfilment standards and returns orchestration
Individual retailer websites	Controlled brand, price and checkout	Cross-merchant comparison, one account, local offer density and shared trust layer
Vertical grocery or diaspora shops	Curated fulfilment and remote gifting	Open multi-vendor supply, broader categories and seller choice
Future international entrants	Capital, technology and cross-border assortment	Local stock truth, assisted informal onboarding, local payments, pickup and category knowledge

The positioning is not "Zimbabwe's Amazon" in public marketing. That comparison creates expectations of owned inventory, next-day national delivery, broad guarantees and deep subsidy. The better investor analogy is an **asset-light managed marketplace with local commerce infrastructure**, built cell by cell.

Part III - Product and transaction model

13. The four transaction lanes

Lane A - Buy Now

Used for standardised products with clear price, current stock and predictable delivery or pickup. The customer pays through a licensed payment provider, receives an order number, and the merchant must accept within a defined period.

Lane B - Reserve and Collect

Used for high-value, limited-stock or bulky items. The customer may place a refundable reservation, deposit or no-payment hold depending on PSP and merchant capability. The seller confirms readiness, the customer receives a collection code, and the order closes only after confirmed collection or expiry.

Lane C - Request a Quote

Used for quantities, services, installation, variable delivery or negotiated commercial orders. The buyer submits a structured request; selected merchants respond in a standard format. Shoppage records response time, quoted scope, price validity and outcome. A WhatsApp message may supplement the process but cannot replace the structured record.

Lane D - Pre-order and Group Buy

Used later for import consolidation, diaspora campaigns or supplier-backed deals. It must have a real threshold, supplier commitment, closing date, refund rule and delivery window. It cannot use fake countdowns or uncertain stock.

The transaction lane is a property of the product-offer combination, not merely the category. The same inverter could be Buy Now at one merchant and Reserve and Collect at another.

14. Shared catalogue and seller-offer model

The platform should maintain one **Master Product** for a normalised product or variant, with many **Seller Offers**.

Master Product

- canonical title and local aliases;
- brand and manufacturer;
- category and attribute schema;
- model, dimensions and technical specifications;
- approved images and source rights;
- compatibility relationships;
- warranty class, not seller-specific warranty promise;
- restricted-product status;
- provenance and review state.

Seller Offer

- merchant and branch;
- seller SKU;
- transaction lane;
- price, currency and tax display;
- stock state and quantity confidence;
- fulfilment options and lead time;
- seller warranty and return terms;
- freshness timestamp and source;
- promotion state;
- seller performance context.

A product page should display the master data once and compare seller offers beneath it. Duplicate merchant pages should not be created for the same product unless there is a genuinely different variant.

15. Offer freshness system

Freshness must be a control system, not a decorative badge.

Offers receive a freshness window by category and source:

- integrated stock feed: minutes or hours;
- merchant dashboard confirmation: one to seven days;
- assisted agent confirmation: one to seven days with audit trail;
- historical or imported price: reference only and excluded from Buy Now.

The system should automatically downgrade or hide stale Buy Now offers. Repeated stock rejection should reduce seller ranking and may suspend transaction eligibility. A seller should be able to update stock in under ten seconds through dashboard, secure link, WhatsApp workflow or integration, but the confirmation must be attributable to an authenticated user or authorised agent.

16. Search and discovery

Search should prioritise **resolvable local demand** rather than catalogue size.

Ranking inputs at launch:

1. exact product or attribute match;
2. delivery or pickup feasibility for the buyer's location;
3. offer freshness;
4. transaction eligibility;
5. seller acceptance and fulfilment performance;
6. price and total landed cost;
7. compatibility confidence;
8. sponsorship, clearly labelled and never overriding basic relevance or safety.

The default result set should exclude reference-only products unless the user deliberately selects "show reference catalogue." A product with no local offer may invite a request, but it must not appear as available.

Search must support local wording, abbreviations, common misspellings and progressive English, Shona and Ndebele synonyms. Language expansion should be tested against real queries, not generated and published without human review.

17. Product detail and offer comparison

A strong product page should answer:

- What exactly is this product or variant?
- Which local sellers have a current offer?
- What is the total payable amount, including delivery where known?
- When can it be delivered or collected?
- What warranty and return terms apply?
- Is it compatible with the buyer's stated use?
- What evidence supports the seller's trust state?
- What happens if the seller rejects or fails the order?

The page should not be overloaded with long reference descriptions, generic AI copy or videos that delay the core decision. Video is useful for demonstrations, installations and condition evidence, but not as a substitute for structured specifications.

18. Cart, checkout and split orders

The first public release should avoid unnecessary multi-seller complexity. The recommended sequence is:

- pilot: one seller per checkout;
- controlled launch: multi-seller cart permitted, but split into seller sub-orders with explicit delivery charges and separate acceptance;
- later: consolidated delivery only where an operational partner can physically combine parcels.

Checkout must capture delivery location, recipient, contact preference, currency, fulfilment method and acceptance of terms. Payment status and order status must be separate. A “paid” transaction is not automatically accepted, shipped or completed.

19. Order state machine

Every order should move through defined states:

1. Created
2. Payment pending
3. Payment confirmed or payment failed
4. Seller acknowledgement pending
5. Accepted, rejected or partially accepted
6. Ready for pickup or handed to carrier
7. In transit
8. Delivered or collected
9. Customer acceptance window
10. Completed, return requested, dispute opened or cancelled
11. Refund pending
12. Refunded, replaced or dispute closed

State changes require timestamps, actor identity and evidence. Manual overrides must be logged. No seller or support agent should be able to erase order history.

20. Returns, refunds and complaints

Returns policy should be category-specific and consistent with the Consumer Protection Act and merchant agreements. Shoppage must distinguish:

- seller fault: wrong item, misdescription, non-delivery, hidden defect or unhonoured warranty;
- customer change of mind where allowed;
- transit damage;
- compatibility error;
- installation or misuse dispute;
- perishable, hygiene-sensitive, custom or otherwise restricted returns.

The platform should publish who pays return transport and when the refund clock starts. Seller-funded refunds should not depend on informal promises. The PSP and settlement design must support reversals or a controlled reserve; otherwise Shoppage should limit prepaid categories until the process is reliable.

21. Trust framework

Trust should be expressed as separate evidence states:

State	Meaning	Public label
Sourced	Record exists from an identified source; merchant has not claimed it	Listed record
Claimed	Authorised representative controls the page	Claimed business
Identity checked	Phone, responsible person and business evidence checked	Identity checked
Trading checked	Location, products and recent trading evidence checked	Trading checked
Performance proven	Sufficient accepted and fulfilled orders with low complaint rate	Proven fulfilment

No single green badge should collapse these distinctions. Performance ratings require minimum sample sizes and should show the period covered. Reviews should be tied to verified transactions or clearly labelled as unverified.

22. Buyer protection model

At launch, buyer protection should be operationally narrow and credible:

- payment confirmation and order record;
- seller acknowledgement deadline;
- clear cancellation and refund route;
- support case number;
- delivery or pickup evidence;
- defined remedy for seller rejection or non-fulfilment;
- fraud and restricted-goods controls.

Shoppage should not promise escrow, insurance or unconditional guarantees until a licensed payment structure, reserve policy and fraud-loss budget exist.

Part IV - Merchant, operations, payment and fulfilment model

23. Seller acquisition and controlled activation

Shoppage should acquire sellers as an operating pipeline, not as a registration campaign. The objective is not the number of accounts created. The objective is the number of merchants capable of accepting and fulfilling real orders with accurate catalogue data.

The seller pipeline is:

Prospect → Contacted → Qualified → Evidence received → Contracted → Catalogue ready → Test-order ready → Live → Transaction active → At risk or paused.

Each state must have an owner, next action, due date and reason code. A merchant cannot move to "live" merely because a phone number was confirmed. Activation requires an approved seller agreement, valid settlement instructions, category readiness, agreed fulfilment methods, returns responsibility and a successful test transaction.

The 200,000-company dataset should support prospect scoring. It can identify category, location, likely formality, digital presence and potential branch structure. It should not be converted automatically into public seller pages. Prospect scores should prioritise:

- category relevance to the launch wedge;
- evidence of current trading;
- product breadth or specialist depth;
- reliable contactability;
- geographic usefulness within the launch cell;
- willingness to publish current prices or quote within a defined SLA;
- ability to fulfil or support collection;
- reputation signals that can be corroborated;
- readiness to complete settlement and tax documentation.

The first 25 sellers should be deliberately unrepresentative in a useful way: include formal distributors, specialist retailers, market-based merchants, installers and one or two manufacturers. This exposes the platform to different catalogue and fulfilment realities before scale.

A launch seller should be rejected or deferred when there is no accountable owner, no stable trading location or collection process, no credible fulfilment capacity, repeated refusal to state customer terms, restricted-goods risk, unresolved complaints, or an expectation that Shoppage will invent stock and prices on the seller's behalf.

24. Three onboarding lanes

24.1 Assisted lane

This lane is for micro-merchants, informal sellers and businesses with fewer than roughly 50 launch offers. A field or remote onboarding agent captures identity evidence, location, payment and settlement details, product images, price, stock state, warranty and fulfilment terms. AI may extract drafts from images or voice notes, but the merchant or authorised agent must confirm every commercial claim.

The target is not zero human work. It is a repeatable, measurable process with a declining cost per activated merchant. The agent should use a single checklist and standard category templates. The first ten offers should be published only after a second-person quality review.

24.2 Self-service bulk lane

This lane is for retailers with approximately 50 to 5,000 offers. Merchants receive category-specific spreadsheets or CSV templates with required and optional fields, saved column mappings, image-link support and a validation report. Errors are queued by type: missing attribute, invalid price, duplicate, unmatched product, restricted item, poor image or unsupported delivery zone.

The system must preserve the merchant's original source row and transformation history. A corrected import should update only fields owned by the merchant and must not overwrite the master product without review.

24.3 Integrated lane

This lane is for chains, distributors, ERP users and high-volume merchants. It uses a scheduled feed or API for price, stock, branch and order acknowledgement. The contract must define the authoritative source for every field, update frequency, failure behaviour and correction responsibility.

An integration is not live until it passes reconciliation tests for products, prices, stock, taxes, currency, cancellations, returns and branch routing. The platform must be able to disable a broken feed without disabling the merchant's entire account.

25. Merchant readiness score

Merchant readiness should be an internal operational score, not a vanity badge. It has five components:

1. **Identity and accountability:** responsible person, contact verification, business evidence and settlement ownership.
2. **Catalogue quality:** product match rate, required attributes, image quality, price completeness and currency clarity.
3. **Inventory reliability:** stock confirmation method, freshness and historical variance between stated and actual availability.
4. **Fulfilment readiness:** acknowledgement, picking, packaging, pickup handoff, delivery responsibility and return address.
5. **Service responsiveness:** response time, complaint handling and willingness to correct data.

A merchant can be publicly visible but not transaction-enabled. For example, a useful specialist may accept quote requests while failing the requirements for prepaid Buy Now orders. This is preferable to falsely treating every seller as equally ready.

The internal launch threshold should be at least 80 out of 100 with no critical control failure. A critical failure overrides the total score.

26. Merchant service levels and enforcement

Every transaction-enabled seller signs category-specific service levels. The launch baseline is:

Obligation	Initial standard	Enforcement
Order acknowledgement	Within 30 minutes during trading hours; maximum 2 hours	Ranking reduction, auto-cancel or temporary pause after repeated breaches
Stock and price accuracy	Seller must honour confirmed offer or provide customer-approved remedy	Incident score, refund responsibility, possible offer suspension
Dispatch or collection readiness	By the promised window	Late event recorded; repeated failure limits delivery options
Complaint response	Initial response within one business day	Escalation to Shoppage operations
Refund cooperation	Evidence and approval within defined policy clock	Settlement hold or reserve draw where contractually permitted

Service levels should vary by category and trading hours. A seller cannot be penalised for missing a nighttime acknowledgement if the offer accurately states that orders are processed the next morning. The platform must distinguish deliberate misrepresentation from operational delay.

Enforcement should be progressive: education, warning, ranking reduction, feature restriction, temporary pause and termination. Fraud, restricted products, falsified identity or repeated non-delivery may justify immediate suspension.

27. The marketplace operations console

The operations console is the command centre of the business. It should be built before promotional dashboards. Its default view is exception-led, showing what needs human intervention now.

Core queues are:

- seller applications and evidence exceptions;
- unmatched or disputed catalogue records;
- stale prices and stock;
- order acknowledgement overdue;
- payment received but order not accepted;
- dispatch and delivery exceptions;
- pickup not collected;
- cancellation and partial fulfilment;
- return and refund cases;
- suspicious behaviour and duplicate accounts;
- customer complaints;
- settlement discrepancies;
- data-rights corrections and suppression requests.

Every queue item requires priority, owner, clock, current state, next action, evidence and resolution code. Management should measure backlog age, not only backlog count.

The console must support controlled overrides. Operations may correct a delivery state or issue a refund instruction, but the original event remains immutable. Permissions should be role-based and high-risk actions should require two-person approval.

28. Customer support operating model

Customer support is part of the product, not a cost centre added later. At launch, support should be available through web form, WhatsApp and telephone during defined hours. Every contact must create or attach to a platform case.

The support hierarchy is:

1. self-service order status and policy explanation;
2. frontline resolution using approved scripts and evidence;
3. seller or courier coordination;
4. payments and refund escalation;
5. trust-and-safety or legal escalation.

Support agents should not improvise commercial promises. They need decision trees for seller rejection, no stock, late delivery, damaged parcel, wrong product, missing component, payment mismatch, customer unavailability and suspected fraud.

The key support metric is **cost per completed order after preventable-contact reduction**. A falling response time with rising repeat contacts is not improvement. Root causes must be fed back into catalogue rules, seller SLAs, checkout copy and fulfilment design.

29. Fulfilment architecture

Shoppage should start with **seller-held inventory and orchestrated fulfilment**. It should not buy a fleet or warehouse merely to look like a marketplace. The platform controls the promise, routing, evidence and exceptions; qualified partners or merchants perform physical movement.

There are four launch fulfilment methods:

29.1 Merchant pickup

The customer collects from the seller or designated pickup point. Shoppage displays address instructions, trading hours, readiness state, collection code and expiry. Collection is completed by one-time code, signed confirmation or scan.

Pickup is not operationally free. The platform must manage readiness, customer communication, no-shows, identity, substitution and refunds. However, it avoids delivery cost and is suitable for bulky or high-value items.

29.2 Seller delivery

The merchant delivers using its own vehicle or courier. Shoppage records the promise, proof and performance. This is useful for merchants already delivering building materials and appliances, but the platform must not display a guaranteed window it cannot enforce.

29.3 Platform-arranged courier

Shoppage books a licensed courier partner, passes parcel and address data under an approved agreement, receives status events and manages customer communication. Courier charges should be quoted transparently and the commercial agreement must define loss, damage, re-delivery and return responsibility.

29.4 Freight or project delivery

Bulky building materials, multiple drop points or job-site delivery require a quote rather than instant parcel pricing. The order remains in a structured quote state until delivery cost, vehicle type, loading responsibility and timing are accepted.

Zimbabwe Post’s national location footprint and courier services make it one candidate for pickup or last-mile partnerships, but Shoppage should also contract private couriers and merchant fleets where service evidence is stronger. No partner should become a single point of failure.

30. Delivery-zone economics

The country should be divided into operating zones, not merely provinces. Each zone has:

- eligible pickup and delivery methods;
- postcode, suburb, landmark and polygon rules;
- courier price table;
- maximum parcel characteristics;
- service days and cutoff times;
- failed-delivery assumptions;
- return route;
- contribution-margin threshold.

A customer should set the delivery area before seeing a hard delivery promise. Offers outside the area can remain visible for pickup or quote, but should not pretend to support a delivery service that has not been validated.

Each cell must pass three tests before public expansion:

1. at least two independent fulfilment routes or a merchant-delivery fallback;
2. on-time rate above 90% over at least 100 completed deliveries or pickups;
3. positive delivery contribution after failed attempts, customer support and return movement.

31. Pickup-point network

A pickup network may become a major advantage because it reduces failed deliveries, reaches customers with informal addresses and creates physical trust. It should be piloted through existing merchants, service stations, post offices, pharmacies or other high-footfall businesses rather than leased standalone sites.

A pickup partner needs secure storage, scanning or code verification, published hours, chain-of-custody records, liability rules and a per-parcel fee. High-value goods require stronger identity controls and limited holding periods.

The pilot should compare home delivery and pickup on cost, collection rate, support contacts, damage and customer satisfaction. Expansion occurs only where pickup reduces total fulfilment cost and does not create theft or congestion risk.

32. Payment architecture

Shoppage should integrate a licensed payment service provider and keep **payment state separate from order acceptance and settlement state**. Paynow's documented checkout options include bank cards, Zimswitch and local mobile-money methods such as EcoCash, OneMoney, InnBucks and O'mari, making it a practical initial integration candidate subject to commercial and legal due diligence.

The payment flow is:

1. customer creates order;
2. PSP creates payment request;
3. Shoppage verifies server-to-server payment notification;
4. order moves to paid-pending-acceptance;
5. seller accepts or rejects within SLA;
6. fulfilment occurs;
7. settlement becomes payable under the merchant agreement;
8. refunds, fees, reserves and adjustments are reconciled.

Shoppage should not rely on a browser redirect as proof of payment. It must verify the PSP notification and reconcile the transaction against the PSP report and bank movement.

The launch should support one primary PSP and a documented fallback or manual recovery process. Payment methods that cannot support reliable confirmation, refunds or settlement evidence should not be offered for prepaid orders, though they may be used for pay-on-collection under controlled conditions.

33. Settlement design

Merchant settlement is one of the highest-risk operating processes. The platform must decide, with legal advice and PSP contracts, whether funds settle directly to merchants, to a PSP-managed sub-merchant structure, or to Shoppage before onward settlement. Shoppage should avoid holding customer funds under an informal arrangement.

The preferred launch design is a licensed PSP or acquiring partner that contractually supports marketplace or sub-merchant settlement. Where that is not available, Shoppage may begin with direct merchant settlement and charge platform fees separately, but customer protection and refunds become more difficult. This trade-off must be explicit.

A settlement ledger must show:

- gross order amount by currency;
- tax and delivery components;
- PSP charges;
- Shoppage transaction fee;
- seller-funded promotion or refund;
- platform-funded goodwill adjustment;
- reserve or hold;
- net payable amount;
- payout date and reference.

Settlements should be generated from immutable order and payment events, not editable spreadsheets. Finance reviews exception reports daily and performs a full PSP-bank-order reconciliation at least weekly during pilot.

34. Refunds, chargebacks and reserves

The platform should maintain a risk reserve or contractual right of set-off for transaction-enabled sellers, calibrated by category, order history and dispute rate. A new merchant, high-value electronics seller or seller with long warranty exposure should not receive the same settlement terms as a proven low-risk merchant.

Refund options are:

- PSP reversal before final settlement;
- refund through the original payment method;
- merchant-funded refund deducted from settlement;
- platform-funded goodwill with later recovery;
- customer-approved replacement or partial refund.

Store credit should not be the default remedy for a cash or card purchase unless the customer chooses it and the law permits it.

Chargebacks require a standard evidence pack: order, customer acceptance, seller acknowledgement, delivery proof, product description, communication and refund history. The business must budget for fraud and chargeback loss rather than assume every disputed payment can be recovered.

35. Reconciliation and financial controls

The finance control model should use a three-way daily reconciliation:

1. Shoppage order and refund ledger;
2. PSP transaction report;
3. bank or settlement account movement.

A fourth reconciliation compares seller payouts to the merchant payable ledger. Differences are classified by timing, failed payment, duplicate notification, fee, refund, chargeback, currency, manual adjustment or unknown.

No person should be able to create a merchant, change bank details and approve a payout alone. Bank-detail changes require step-up authentication, independent callback and a cooling period for high-risk changes.

The accounting design should separate:

- gross merchandise value, which is not automatically Shoppage revenue;
- Shoppage transaction and subscription revenue;
- payment and delivery pass-through amounts;
- merchant payables;
- customer refund liabilities;
- reserves and chargeback provisions;
- promotion credits;
- tax liabilities.

Management accounts must report contribution margin by category, seller, transaction lane and operating cell. Aggregate GMV can hide loss-making fulfilment and support.

36. Diaspora transaction model

Diaspora commerce should be a targeted product lane, not a generic international marketing slogan. The customer pays remotely for delivery or pickup in Zimbabwe. The platform must verify recipient details, consent to share contact information, substitution rules and proof of receipt.

The first diaspora use cases should be categories with clear specifications and strong local utility: backup power, appliances, building-project milestones, school or household essentials and verified service bundles. Food gifting may be added through controlled partners, but perishables require different fulfilment and refund rules.

The checkout should support “buyer” and “recipient” as separate roles. The buyer controls payment and refund instructions; the recipient receives delivery updates and confirms receipt. High-value orders may require a recipient identity check or delivery PIN.

Diaspora payments introduce card-fraud, currency, chargeback and cross-border tax questions. Shoppage should use PSP-supported international methods and avoid informal remittance structures.

37. Temu-like mechanics that are acceptable

The user's ambition to adopt useful Temu-style mechanics should focus on demand aggregation and price discovery, not manipulative gamification.

The acceptable mechanics are:

Group buy

A merchant states a lower price if a minimum quantity is reached before a deadline. Customer funds should be authorised or collected under PSP-supported rules, with automatic refund if the threshold is missed. The merchant must prove supply and delivery capacity.

Preorder

The product is not currently in local stock. The page states source, expected arrival, deposit, cancellation rights and risk. Preorder money should not finance unverified imports without clear protection.

Request-network aggregation

Multiple similar buyer requests are grouped and sent to qualified merchants. Merchants bid on the structured requirement. This is particularly strong for building materials, school supplies and contractor bundles.

Price-drop alert

Customers save a product or requirement. Alerts are sent only when a current local offer meets the threshold. The platform should not fabricate "was" prices or urgency.

Referral credit

A customer or creator receives a fixed, disclosed credit after a completed and non-refunded order. Outcome commissions should begin only after attribution, fraud detection and reconciliation are proven.

Shoppage should prohibit fake countdowns, wheel games, hidden recurring charges, forced contact access, misleading discounts and social-pressure dark patterns.

Part V - Catalogue, data, AI and technology

38. Data ownership and rights doctrine

Shoppage’s data doctrine should be: **use what the business has the right to use; label what the business knows; preserve where it came from; and provide correction and deletion routes.**

Every external dataset enters a rights register with:

- source and acquisition method;
- contractual or public-use basis;
- fields obtained;
- permitted public display;
- permitted internal analysis;
- permitted AI retrieval or training;
- image and trademark rights;
- retention period;
- correction and suppression route;
- responsible owner.

Default status is blocked until rights are recorded. Technical access is not legal permission.

The company dataset should be divided into public evidence, merchant-claimed data and internal prospecting attributes. Internal scores and inferred labels should not be published as facts. A merchant may claim and correct its profile after identity checks. Suppression requests should be acknowledged within 24 hours and resolved under a documented SLA.

Facebook and WhatsApp content should not be scraped or republished without a lawful basis and, where appropriate, administrator or merchant permission. Groups can be distribution partners through export cards, approved feeds or campaigns. They are not a free national product database.

39. Master catalogue construction

The master catalogue should be built category by category. The objective is product identity and comparability, not word count.

The hierarchy is:

Category → Product family → Master product → Variant → Compatibility relationship → Seller offer.

For each launch category, the team defines:

- required attributes;
- variant rules;
- units and measurement standards;
- brand and model normalisation;
- local aliases and misspellings;
- image requirements;
- compatibility rules;
- restricted claims;
- return and warranty characteristics;
- matching confidence threshold.

The first 5,000 live offers may map to 1,500 to 3,000 master products. That is acceptable. A 100,000-record reference file is valuable only after duplicates, model errors, invalid specifications and rights issues are controlled.

A seller cannot create a new master product merely by changing the title. New-product requests enter an exception queue. High-confidence exact matches can be automated; ambiguous records require review.

40. Offer freshness and inventory truth

Freshness is a first-class field. Each seller offer stores the source, last seller confirmation, last system update, last order outcome and confidence state.

Freshness rules should vary:

- fast-moving or scarce goods: confirm daily or through a live feed;
- stable stocked lines: confirm every three to seven days;
- made-to-order or quote items: display lead time and last capacity confirmation;
- reference-only products: never show a current price or “in stock” state.

A stale offer is not deleted; it is demoted or hidden from transaction results and preserved for audit. The seller receives a one-tap confirmation workflow. Repeated false confirmations reduce reliability score.

Order outcomes are stronger than clicks. If a seller repeatedly rejects “in stock” orders, the platform should automatically downgrade the offer confidence and eventually pause it.

41. Compatibility graph

The compatibility graph is a genuine differentiator in power, electrical, plumbing and building systems. It should be rules-based and evidence-backed before using generative AI.

For backup power, example entities and relationships include:

- battery voltage, chemistry, usable capacity and maximum current;
- inverter voltage, power, surge rating and supported battery type;
- panel voltage and current range;
- charge controller limits;
- cable size by current and distance;
- breaker, fuse and isolator requirements;
- manufacturer-approved and installer-validated combinations.

Every compatibility relationship needs a source, confidence and review date. “Compatible” should distinguish technically possible, manufacturer-supported and locally installer-validated. High-risk electrical recommendations should include a professional-installation warning and never replace an engineer or licensed installer.

A bundle engine can then recommend a complete system, flag missing components and explain why an alternative is unsuitable. This creates value beyond a generic price list and reduces returns caused by incorrect combinations.

42. Search and ranking model

Search should begin with deterministic retrieval and transparent ranking. The query pipeline includes spelling normalisation, local synonyms, unit interpretation, brand and model extraction, category classification and location constraints.

The ranking sequence should favour:

1. exact or strong product match;
2. transaction-eligible current local offer;
3. delivery or pickup feasibility;
4. seller acceptance and fulfilment performance;
5. price and total landed cost;
6. response speed for quote lanes;
7. customer preference and sponsored placement.

Sponsorship may influence rank only within an eligible set. A paid stale or incompatible offer must not outrank a suitable current offer. Sponsored results must be labelled.

A reference-library result can appear when no current local offer exists, but it should lead to “request this product” rather than imply availability.

43. Responsible AI scope

AI should reduce labour and improve data quality. It should not invent commercial facts.

Approved launch uses are:

- extract draft product fields from merchant images, PDFs, spreadsheets and voice notes;
- normalise titles and units;
- propose master-product matches;
- detect likely duplicates and image reuse;
- translate or expand English, Shona and Ndebele search terms;
- prioritise stale or anomalous records;
- draft seller replies and support summaries;
- classify complaints and fraud signals;
- assist bundle and compatibility explanation from governed data.

AI may not independently publish price, stock, warranty, verification, delivery promise or legal status. It may not make a high-impact fraud or seller-suspension decision without human review.

The model layer should be provider-independent. Each task has a test set, cost limit, accuracy threshold and fallback. High-volume classification and extraction should use the cheapest model that passes the evaluation. Sensitive personal data should not be sent to a provider without an approved processing agreement and minimisation controls.

44. AI evaluation programme

Before launch, create a 500-query Zimbabwe-specific test set covering:

- local product terms and misspellings;
- Shona and Ndebele expressions;
- power-system compatibility;
- location and landmark queries;
- currency and unit ambiguity;
- fresh local offer versus reference-only distinction;
- restricted or unsafe requests;
- buyer intent for Buy Now, pickup and quote.

Outputs are scored for retrieval accuracy, offer truth, hallucinated availability, unsafe advice, local-language handling and latency. A model release fails if it invents a local seller, price or stock state.

Merchant extraction should be evaluated separately using real catalogues and photos. The target is not perfect autonomous publishing. The target is a measurable reduction in agent minutes per accepted offer while maintaining quality.

45. Technology architecture decision

The recommended launch stack is a **modular monolith**, not microservices or Kubernetes.

- **Commerce kernel:** Vendure or an equivalently mature headless commerce framework, extended for multi-vendor offers, seller sub-orders, quote and reservation states.
- **Storefront and portals:** Next.js web applications for shopper, seller and operations experiences.
- **Primary database:** PostgreSQL.
- **Jobs and cache:** Redis-backed queues for imports, notifications, search indexing and reconciliations.
- **Search:** Typesense, Meilisearch or OpenSearch selected after a Zimbabwe-specific relevance and operating-cost test.
- **Object storage:** S3-compatible storage for images, evidence and exports.
- **Payments:** PSP adapter layer beginning with one approved Zimbabwe integration.
- **Notifications:** email, SMS and WhatsApp through adapter services.
- **Analytics:** event pipeline into a warehouse or analytical database after core volumes justify it.

The architecture must separate modules logically—catalogue, offers, sellers, orders, payments, fulfilment, returns, settlements, trust and notifications—while deploying them simply. A service should be separated physically only when independent scaling, security or deployment needs are proven.

46. Core domain model

The minimum entities are:

- Customer and Recipient
- Merchant, Branch and User
- Master Product and Variant
- Seller Offer and Price History
- Inventory Confirmation
- Compatibility Edge
- Cart and Checkout Session
- Order and Seller Sub-order
- Payment, Refund and Chargeback
- Fulfilment, Parcel, Pickup and Delivery Event
- Return and Dispute
- Settlement and Merchant Payable
- Trust Evidence and Review
- Request, Quote and Reservation
- Promotion and Attribution Event
- Source and Rights Record

Every commercial entity should use immutable identifiers. External IDs from Facebook, Google, a PSP or ERP are references, not primary identity.

47. Integration policy

Every integration defines:

- authoritative fields;
- read and write direction;
- authentication and secret rotation;
- timestamp and idempotency behaviour;
- retry and dead-letter handling;
- failure alert;
- data retention;
- merchant consent;
- reconciliation method;
- manual fallback.

Bidirectional stock and price synchronisation should not launch without conflict rules. If a merchant ERP is authoritative for stock, Shoppage must not overwrite it with a customer-service correction. Instead, the correction creates an exception and temporary platform status.

48. Security baseline

The independent security and privacy gate should verify at least:

- multifactor authentication for staff and high-risk merchant users;
- role-based access and least privilege;
- encrypted transport and encrypted sensitive data at rest;
- secure secret management;
- logging of administrative and financial actions;
- tested backups and restoration;
- dependency scanning and patch process;
- rate limiting, bot controls and abuse monitoring;
- secure file upload and malware scanning;
- protection against common web application risks;
- incident-response plan and named contacts;
- penetration test before public payment launch.

Customer card details should remain with the PSP. Shoppage should store tokens or references only where supported.

49. Data-protection operating model

Zimbabwe's 2024 data-controller licensing regulations require commercial processors of personal data to evaluate licensing, appoint a data protection officer and follow defined breach-notification rules. Shoppage should obtain written legal advice and complete the appropriate registration or licence before public operation.

The data programme should include:

- data inventory and lawful purpose by field;
- privacy notice and cookie controls;
- consent and marketing preference records;
- processor agreements;
- access, correction, deletion and objection workflow;
- retention schedule;
- cross-border transfer review;
- breach response capable of notifying the Authority within the required window and affected people where required;
- privacy impact assessment for identity checks, fraud scoring and behavioural analytics.

The platform should collect the minimum identity information needed for the risk. A low-value buyer order does not justify excessive document collection. Seller evidence and payout controls require stronger verification.

50. Reliability and disaster recovery

Launch reliability targets should be realistic but explicit:

- 99.5% monthly availability for buyer checkout and merchant order acknowledgement;
- no loss of confirmed order, payment or settlement events;
- recovery point objective of 15 minutes for transactional data;
- recovery time objective of four hours for core commerce;
- tested restore at least quarterly;
- independent backups in a separate account or region;
- documented manual order and refund recovery process.

Operational dashboards should monitor checkout errors, PSP callback failures, queue backlog, search latency, stale inventory, notification failures, seller acknowledgement and reconciliation differences.

51. Build versus buy doctrine

Shoppage should buy commodity capability and build local differentiation.

Buy or use mature components for authentication, payments, email, SMS, object storage, error monitoring, customer-support tooling and basic commerce functions. Build the seller-offer model, local transaction lanes, assisted onboarding, catalogue matching, compatibility graph, seller performance system, request network and operations console.

A public plugin marketplace is deferred. First-party integrations should be built only when they unlock a meaningful merchant cohort or reduce recurring operating cost. A plugin without distribution or support capacity is a liability, not an asset.

Part VI - Go-to-market and market formation

52. Coverage-cell strategy

Shoppage should not launch “Zimbabwe.” It should launch a **coverage cell**: a bounded buyer area, merchant cluster, category set and fulfilment network that is dense enough to produce reliable outcomes.

A cell is defined by:

- buyer delivery and pickup area;
- anchor merchants and branches;
- launch categories and product depth;
- courier and merchant-delivery routes;
- support ownership;
- price and stock refresh method;
- field activation capacity;
- contribution economics.

The candidate first cell should include one industrial or trade cluster and one adjacent consumer delivery zone. Graniteside–Workington–Southerton is a strong candidate for formal and industrial suppliers. Gazaland or Glen View may provide informal trade density and building-related supply. Msasa offers distributor depth. Database counts are only a starting point; a two-week field audit must verify active merchants, access, courier pickup, safety, operating hours and willingness to transact.

A cell is launch-ready when it has at least 15 transaction-enabled anchor merchants, 5,000 live offers, two fulfilment methods, a tested return route and 200 successful closed-pilot transactions or verified outcomes.

53. Anchor-merchant recruitment

Anchor merchants create catalogue depth and fulfilment reliability. The first recruitment offer should be commercially concrete:

- free setup and first catalogue build;
- waived subscription during pilot;
- transaction fee charged only on completed orders;
- featured placement earned through completeness and performance, not promised permanently;
- weekly operational report;
- direct founder or launch-team support;
- clear exit and data-export rights.

The recruitment pitch is not “join Zimbabwe’s next Amazon.” It is: “We will make your current stock searchable, create controlled orders, coordinate customer communication and prove the resulting sales.”

Each anchor merchant should nominate an accountable operator and executive sponsor. A merchant with no daily order owner is not an anchor, regardless of brand size.

The launch portfolio should avoid excessive concentration. No merchant should represent more than 20% of live offers or projected GMV. At least three sellers should exist for major high-intent product groups where comparison is part of the proposition.

54. Buyer-acquisition sequence

Buyer acquisition should begin after supply and operations pass the closed-pilot gate. The sequence is:

54.1 Existing merchant audiences

Merchants publish Shoppage product and category links to their own WhatsApp status, Facebook pages, customer lists, websites and physical premises. This is the lowest-cost demand because the merchant already has trust and reach.

54.2 High-intent local search

Build indexable category, product, merchant and location pages only where the platform has current local offers and unique structured value. Avoid millions of thin reference pages. Search landing pages should answer availability, location, total cost and compatibility.

54.3 Approved Facebook-group distribution

Work with group administrators on scheduled deal posts, verified merchant collections, request threads or category sponsorships. Use canonical Shoppage links and transparent commercial disclosure. Never automate unauthorised scraping or posting.

54.4 Contractor and installer partnerships

Installers and tradespeople bring repeated demand and can validate compatibility data. Offer business buying lists, quote tools and referral credit tied to completed orders.

54.5 Diaspora campaigns

Target specific use cases—such as paying for a solar backup system or a building-material milestone—rather than broad “shop for home” advertising. Proof of recipient delivery is central to the campaign.

Paid advertising should be limited until conversion, fulfilment and repeat purchase are understood. A marketplace can burn capital buying clicks into operational failure.

55. Social-media operating doctrine

Facebook, WhatsApp, TikTok, Instagram and YouTube are feeders. Shoppage should make sharing easy but keep the commercial record on-platform.

Every share asset should use a canonical URL and display:

- product and variant;
- seller or offer count;
- current price or “request quote”;
- freshness date;
- fulfilment method;
- sponsored disclosure where relevant.

The first share tools are static product cards, merchant collections and 15-second demonstration clips. A full short-video feed is deferred until the core storefront achieves acceptable speed, catalogue quality and conversion. Video should demonstrate use, condition, installation or merchant identity. It should not bury price and terms.

The key strategic metric is **Owned Demand Share**: the percentage of qualified sessions and orders that begin through direct, saved, search, QR, notification, referral or merchant channels controlled by Shoppage rather than paid or platform-dependent media. This share should rise over time.

56. Creator and affiliate programme

Creators may be useful in hardware demonstrations, home projects, solar education and diaspora trust. The launch model is fixed-fee content with clear deliverables, not automatic sales commission.

A creator brief specifies product, merchant consent, factual claims, disclosure, canonical link, publishing period and acceptance test. Payment is released after the content is live and compliant. Attribution is collected for learning but does not determine compensation until duplicate detection, cancellation adjustment and refund reconciliation are stable.

A later affiliate programme may pay on completed and non-refunded transactions. It must exclude self-referrals, duplicate devices, collusion and prohibited claims. High-risk products and financial services remain outside the programme.

57. Market and association partnerships

Market associations, shopping centres, industry associations and business groups can reduce seller-acquisition cost. The partnership proposition is a controlled digital roster, merchant onboarding days, category pages and aggregated demand insights.

Shoppage must not outsource verification authority blindly to market captains or political intermediaries. A partner may attest location or membership, but platform identity and trading checks remain separate. Compensation should be tied to accepted, active merchants and quality—not raw registrations.

A market page is useful only when it has an accurate roster, navigable location, current offers, operating information and a correction route. A decorative “digital twin” without maintenance is deferred.

58. Agency channel

Digital agencies may become a scalable merchant-acquisition and maintenance channel because they already manage websites, social pages and content for local businesses. However, the agency intelligence suite in v3.0 was premature.

The phase-one agency role is simple:

- refer qualified merchants;
- help prepare catalogue files and media;
- install Shoppage links or widgets on client websites;
- support stock and promotion updates;
- receive a fixed activation fee or recurring share for active paid merchants.

Only after Shoppage has first-party transaction density should it launch Price Pulse, Demand Radar or competitive intelligence. Those products must be based on anonymised, rights-cleared and statistically sufficient data. An agency should not receive confidential seller-level information about competitors.

59. Partnerships and institutional route

Priority partnership categories are:

- licensed payment providers;
- courier and pickup networks;
- manufacturers and distributors with authorised product data;
- installer and contractor associations;
- market and shopping-centre operators;
- banks, mobile operators and business-account providers;
- consumer and standards bodies;
- universities or training institutions for merchant digital skills.

Institutional partnerships should follow a proven operating cell. Public-sector endorsement is not a substitute for customer value and can create procurement or governance complexity. The platform should remain capable of operating without a single institutional sponsor.

Part VII - Revenue model, unit economics and financial plan

60. Revenue architecture

Shoppage should use six revenue streams, introduced in sequence.

60.1 Transaction service fee

A fee on completed Buy Now, reservation or verified quote outcomes. The fee must be category-specific because margin, support and fulfilment differ. Initial planning assumption: 5% to 8% gross platform fee, excluding payment and delivery pass-through costs.

60.2 Merchant subscription

A free foundation tier and one paid growth tier during the first year. The paid tier may include more active offers, bulk updates, branch tools, response analytics, promotion credits and integrations. Planning price: US$19 per month or a locally practical equivalent, tested against actual value.

60.3 Fulfilment margin

A transparent margin or booking fee where Shoppage arranges delivery or pickup. This is earned only after failed-delivery and support costs are included.

60.4 Sponsored placement

Clearly labelled sponsored offers, category positions or merchant campaigns. Eligibility requires current offers, acceptable seller performance and relevance. Advertising cannot buy trust status.

60.5 Onboarding and managed services

Paid catalogue digitisation, photography, integration, campaign setup and data cleaning for merchants that require labour beyond the standard package. This is service revenue and must be reported separately from software margin.

60.6 Intelligence and API products

Deferred until sufficient first-party data exists. Potential customers include merchants, manufacturers, agencies and institutions. Products may include aggregate price indices, demand gaps, category performance and anonymised market reports. No launch forecast should depend on this revenue.

61. Pricing principles

Pricing should follow four principles:

1. charge where value is measurable;
2. keep launch packaging simple;
3. separate pass-through costs from platform revenue;
4. avoid a fee stack that makes the informal channel structurally cheaper.

The proposed pilot pricing is:

Product	Planning price	Conditions
Foundation	Free	Limited live offers; standard transaction fee; basic merchant page
Growth	US$19 per month	More offers, bulk tools, analytics, lower promotional friction
Transaction fee	5%–8% by category	Charged on completed, non-refunded transaction value; payment cost separately disclosed or included by contract

The exact fee cannot be decided by competitor benchmarks alone. The willingness-to-pay test should measure whether merchants understand the fee, whether contribution exceeds acquisition and support cost, and whether churn remains acceptable after promotions end.

62. Unit-economics formula

Management should calculate contribution per order as:

Transaction revenue + fulfilment margin + allocated merchant subscription + promotion revenue – PSP cost – courier subsidy – refund and chargeback loss – creator or referral payout – variable support – packaging or pickup cost – variable infrastructure.

GMV is not contribution. Paid orders can destroy cash if the platform subsidises delivery, absorbs refunds and manually resolves every order.

The minimum reporting dimensions are transaction lane, category, seller, cell, payment method, fulfilment method and customer cohort.

A category may remain strategically valuable with low transaction fee if it drives repeat customers or profitable adjacent purchases. That decision must be supported by cohort evidence, not intuition.

63. Illustrative order economics

The following is a planning example, not a forecast.

Buy Now order	Amount (US$)	Treatment
Average merchandise value	42.00	GMV, not Shoppage revenue
Platform fee at 6.5%	2.73	Gross transaction revenue
Fulfilment booking margin	0.75	Only on eligible orders
PSP and transaction variable cost	(1.10)	Depends on method and contract
Support, fraud and refund provision	(0.55)	Cohort-based provision
Variable platform cost	(0.18)	Messaging, search, hosting and tools
Illustrative contribution	1.65	Before fixed payroll and central overhead

At this contribution, 4,000 orders generate only about US$6,600 of order contribution before subscriptions and advertising. This demonstrates why a $19 subscription and a few thousand monthly orders cannot fund a large national operation. The company must keep the team lean, increase repeat rate, protect delivery economics and develop higher-value quote and promotion revenue.

64. Quote and reservation economics

Bulky building and project purchases may have higher order value but weaker payment capture. A verified quote outcome can support either a fixed qualified-lead fee, a percentage service fee or merchant subscription value.

The business should not charge for an unqualified WhatsApp click. A billable quote event requires:

- structured buyer requirement;
- qualified merchant match;
- merchant response within SLA;
- buyer acceptance or verified progression;
- duplicate and fraud checks.

For Reserve and Collect, a deposit can reduce no-shows. The service fee should reflect support and refund risk. High-value equipment may justify inspection, installation coordination or extended protection as separately priced services through qualified partners.

65. Twenty-four-month operating scenarios

These scenarios are management planning ranges. They are not market forecasts.

Scenario at month 24	Operating scale	Monthly outcome
Downside	300 active merchants; 8,000 completed orders; about US$350k GMV	About US$28k revenue; business remains loss-making and must narrow scope
Base	800 active merchants; 18,000 orders; about US$864k GMV	About US$70k–US$80k revenue; modest positive EBITDA possible with disciplined payroll
Upside	1,300 active merchants; 30,000 orders; about US$1.5m GMV	About US$115k–US$130k revenue; supports wider city expansion and deeper integrations

The base case assumes approximately 6% net transaction revenue after the agreed treatment of payment costs, 400 paid merchants at US$19, delivery or booking margin on about 60% of orders, and a modest promotion and managed-service contribution. Any investor model should expose these assumptions line by line.

66. Base-case milestone model

Month 3

- 15 to 25 live merchants;
- 5,000 live offers;
- 200 paid or financially committed pilot outcomes;
- one cell;
- monthly GMV approximately US$20k to US$35k;
- revenue is immaterial; proof is operational.

Month 6

- 60 to 80 active merchants;
- 15,000 to 25,000 offers;
- 1,000 to 1,500 monthly completed outcomes;
- monthly GMV approximately US$55k to US$90k;
- contribution still insufficient for full company overhead.

Month 12

- 150 to 200 active merchants;
- 40,000 to 75,000 offers;
- 3,000 to 4,000 monthly completed outcomes;
- monthly GMV approximately US$140k to US$190k;
- revenue approximately US$15k to US$20k;
- core cells should produce positive contribution before central payroll.

Month 24 base

- 800 active merchants;
- 18,000 monthly completed orders or monetised outcomes;
- monthly GMV approximately US$864k;
- monthly revenue approximately US$75k;
- operating expense controlled near US$60k;
- modest positive EBITDA and cash generation.

67. Capital requirement

A credible 18-to-24-month base plan requires approximately **US$250,000 to US$400,000**, depending on founder compensation, local-versus-remote engineering mix, field headcount and payment integration requirements.

Indicative allocation:

Use	24-month planning range	Control principle
Product and engineering	US$100k–US$150k	Small senior team; reuse mature infrastructure
Operations and support	US$55k–US$90k	Scale with orders and merchants, not registrations
Merchant activation and field work	US$30k–US$50k	Pay for accepted active merchants and catalogue output
Legal, security and compliance	US$20k–US$35k	Complete before regulated or personal-data expansion
Marketing and partnerships	US$20k–US$40k	Release after conversion and fulfilment gates
Contingency and working capital	US$25k–US$45k	Refunds, failures, FX and timing differences

The first 90-day build and closed pilot should be possible within approximately US$60,000 to US$100,000. A founder-built version may cost less in cash but should still account for the economic value and risk of unpaid labour.

68. Cash-control doctrine

The company should protect cash through the following rules:

- no owned warehouse before at least one SKU cohort proves inventory turn, gross margin and shrinkage economics;
- no owned fleet before courier spend and service failures justify a route-level business case;
- no national paid-media campaign before pilot conversion and repeat purchase;
- no unrestricted free delivery;
- no seller payout outside the reconciled settlement ledger;
- no product build without a named metric and retirement condition;
- no headcount hired solely for anticipated scale.

A 13-week rolling cash forecast should be updated weekly. It must include PSP settlement timing, merchant payables, refunds, taxes, payroll, commitments and downside scenarios.

69. Break-even logic

At approximately US$15,000 monthly fixed operating cost, the business needs roughly 9,000 orders at US$1.65 average order contribution if there is no subscription or promotion income. With US$7,500 subscription and promotion contribution, the required order count falls to about 4,500.

At a later US$60,000 monthly cost base, the business requires a diversified contribution mix. The base month-24 scenario should generate approximately:

- US$50k to US$55k net transaction contribution and fees;
- US$7.6k subscriptions;
- US$8k delivery or booking margin;
- US$8k to US$10k promotion, managed services or intelligence;
- less variable losses and costs already reflected in net transaction contribution.

Break-even should be evaluated by cash and by accounting profit. Growth in merchant payables can temporarily make cash look strong; it is not free capital.

Part VIII - Organisation, governance and compliance

70. Launch team

The first operating team should be small and senior:

- founder / chief executive and commercial lead;
- product and operations lead;
- senior full-stack or technical lead;
- one additional engineer or strong product developer;
- catalogue and seller-activation lead;
- customer support and fulfilment coordinator;
- finance and reconciliation support, initially fractional;
- external legal, privacy and security advisers.

Field agents, photographers and category experts can begin as trained contractors with output-based controls. The company should avoid building a large sales force before activation economics are proven.

71. Role accountability

Every critical process has a single accountable owner:

Process	Accountable owner	Core evidence
Seller activation	Marketplace operations lead	Readiness score and test order
Catalogue quality	Catalogue lead	Match rate, rejection and correction log
Order and fulfilment	Operations lead	SLA and exception ledger
Payments and settlements	Finance owner	Daily and weekly reconciliation
Privacy and security	DPO / security owner	Registers, incidents and control tests
Product release	Product and technical leads	Acceptance tests and rollback plan

The founder may hold several roles during pilot, but the responsibilities should remain explicit. “The team” is not an accountable owner.

72. Governance cadence

Daily launch stand-up

Review paid orders awaiting acceptance, fulfilment exceptions, refunds, support backlog, PSP differences and platform incidents.

Weekly operating review

Review cell scorecard, merchant activation, catalogue quality, conversion, seller failure, delivery, support cost, contribution and cash.

Monthly decision review

Approve category or cell expansion, pricing changes, major releases, hiring, partner concentration and risk actions. Update the decision register.

Quarterly board or investor review

Report verified operating evidence, not vanity totals. Separate active merchants from registered merchants, current offers from reference products, completed orders from clicks, and software margin from managed services.

73. Legal-entity and contractual structure

The operating company should own the Shoppage brand, software, merchant contracts, customer terms and intellectual property. Related-party services, founder assets and historical data contributions should be documented through written assignment or licence agreements.

Core contracts are:

- customer terms of use and sale process;
- merchant marketplace agreement;
- privacy notice and data-processing terms;
- PSP agreement;
- courier and pickup-partner agreements;
- employee and contractor IP/confidentiality agreements;
- data-source licences;
- creator and affiliate terms;
- acceptable-use and restricted-products policy.

The contracts must accurately describe who is seller of record, who receives funds, who issues tax invoices, when a contract forms, who carries delivery risk and who funds refunds. Marketing language must match the legal structure.

74. Consumer protection programme

The Consumer Protection Act should be translated into operating controls, including clear pricing, supplier identity, fair terms, complaint routes, cancellation and return handling, accurate advertising and records.

Every product or offer page should identify the seller, price and currency, key limitations, fulfilment terms and applicable warranty. Material terms should not be hidden behind a generic link after payment.

The platform should maintain a complaint register with category, seller, value, root cause, resolution and time. Repeated issues trigger seller remediation or suspension. Customer support scripts and merchant contracts should be reviewed by Zimbabwean counsel before launch.

75. Tax and fiscalisation workstream

Tax treatment depends on whether Shoppage acts as agent, principal, service provider or payment intermediary. The finance and legal design must determine:

- which party records gross merchandise sales;
- who issues fiscal tax invoices for goods and platform fees;
- VAT registration and treatment;
- withholding or other taxes on merchant and foreign-service payments;
- treatment of delivery and promotion fees;
- currency translation and accounting;
- seller tax-information obligations;
- retention of transaction records.

Shoppage should not assume that the platform's GMV is revenue. It should obtain a written accounting and tax memo before the first public payment. ZIMRA's digital-services rules must also be considered for foreign software and marketplace service providers used by the business.

76. Restricted-products policy

The initial marketplace should exclude products that create disproportionate safety, licensing, counterfeit or age-verification risk. These include weapons, prescription medicines, controlled substances, alcohol and nicotine products, hazardous chemicals, wildlife contraband, illegal surveillance tools, financial products, explicit adult goods and other regulated categories until specialist programmes exist.

Electrical and solar categories also require controls. Shoppage should prohibit unsafe installation claims, counterfeit certification and seller representations that the platform has independently tested a product when it has not.

77. Trust and safety operations

Trust and safety should monitor:

- duplicate and synthetic seller identity;
- stolen or repeated product images;
- unrealistic prices;
- payment diversion attempts;
- counterfeit and restricted goods;
- review manipulation;
- customer abuse and chargeback fraud;
- collusion between sellers, agents and creators;
- account takeover and bank-detail changes;
- harassment or unsafe collection arrangements.

Risk scoring prioritises review but does not replace human judgement for high-impact decisions. Appeals should be available, documented and independent from the original decision where practical.

78. Risk register

The principal risks are:

Risk	Early indicator	Primary response
Sellers fail to honour stock or price	Rejection and substitution rise	Tight freshness, deposits, ranking and suspension
Fulfilment destroys contribution	Delivery subsidy and support rise	Zone pricing, pickup, merchant delivery, cell pause
Data-rights challenge	Suppression requests or source dispute	Rights register, blocked-by-default publication
Payment or settlement failure	Reconciliation differences and late payouts	PSP controls, reserve, daily finance review
Buyer trust remains weak	Low prepaid conversion, high support	Stronger protection, pickup and verified outcomes
Scope overwhelms team	Backlog grows while orders fail	Binding kill list and quarterly scope reset
Merchant concentration	One seller dominates GMV	Cohort diversification and exposure limits
Political or market interference	Access or partner pressure	Neutral policies, audit trails and multiple channels
Currency instability	Price disputes and margin loss	Offer currency controls and short validity
Cyber incident	Unusual access or data leak	Security baseline, incident response and insurance review

A detailed register in the appendices assigns likelihood, impact, owner, mitigation, contingency and review date.

Part IX - Execution roadmap and proof system

79. First 30 days: prove the operating thesis

The first month is not primarily a coding sprint. It is an evidence sprint.

Week 1: decision lock

- approve the four transaction lanes;
- select two candidate Harare cells;
- confirm restricted categories;
- appoint legal, privacy and payment advisers;
- define customer and merchant responsibility;
- create the decision register and kill list.

Week 2: field and partner validation

- interview at least 30 merchants across the launch wedge;
- collect real catalogue files and order processes;
- test courier pickup and delivery quotes;
- obtain PSP integration and settlement options;
- map returns and refund constraints;
- recruit the first five anchors conditionally.

Week 3: catalogue and process prototype

- define launch taxonomy and required attributes;
- match at least 500 real offers to master products;
- prototype Buy Now, Reserve and Quote flows;
- write seller onboarding, order, cancellation and refund SOPs;
- calculate unit economics for ten real baskets.

Week 4: gate review

Proceed only if at least 15 viable merchant prospects, 2,000 potential current offers, one workable PSP route, two fulfilment options and a legally credible operating structure exist. Otherwise narrow the cell or category before building further.

80. Days 31–90: build and closed pilot

Days 31–45

- implement seller, branch, master product and offer model;
- build assisted and CSV onboarding;
- create operations queues;
- integrate search and basic storefront;
- complete security and privacy design review.

Days 46–60

- implement one-seller checkout, PSP status, seller acknowledgement and pickup;
- implement quote and reservation state machines;
- build notification adapters;
- complete daily reconciliation and refund process;
- onboard ten real merchants and 2,500 offers.

Days 61–75

- add courier booking or controlled manual orchestration;
- build customer order tracking and support cases;
- add returns, disputes, trust evidence and seller SLA reporting;
- onboard remaining launch merchants and reach 5,000 offers;
- conduct penetration and recovery tests.

Days 76–90

- complete at least 200 paid or financially committed closed-pilot outcomes;
- resolve every critical exception;
- measure conversion, fulfilment, cancellation, support and contribution;
- obtain legal and security launch sign-off;
- hold public-launch gate review.

81. Public-launch gate

Public launch requires all of the following:

- 15 to 25 anchor merchants live;
- at least 5,000 current offers;
- at least 200 closed-pilot orders or verified outcomes;
- seller acknowledgement at or above 95%;
- seller-caused cancellation at or below 5%;
- on-time delivery or pickup readiness at or above 90%;
- payment, refund and settlement reconciliation complete;
- no unresolved critical security, privacy, rights or consumer-protection issue;
- support can resolve the top ten exception types;
- contribution economics known by transaction lane.

Failing a gate means delay or narrower release. It does not mean lowering the metric after marketing has been booked.

82. Months 4–6: stabilise one cell

Priorities are repeat purchase, catalogue freshness, merchant quality and contribution.

Build:

- multi-seller cart with seller sub-orders if single-seller checkout is stable;
- saved items and price alerts;
- better quote comparison;
- pickup-point pilot;
- merchant bulk tools;
- category-specific returns;
- basic promotion product;
- installer and contractor accounts.

Do not enter a second city. Expand only within the proven Harare cell or to an adjacent cell sharing fulfilment and support.

83. Months 7–12: replicate carefully

A second Harare cell or tightly controlled Bulawayo pilot becomes eligible only after three consecutive months of positive core-cell contribution and stable support.

Potential additions:

- enterprise feeds;
- diaspora recipient workflow;
- group buy for selected products;
- product bundles and compatibility assistant;
- agency referral programme;
- manufacturer data partnerships;
- enhanced sponsored placement;
- first-party merchant benchmarking.

The month-12 review determines whether Shoppage has earned the right to call itself a scalable marketplace.

84. Months 13–24: scale or concentrate

The base strategy is to grow to 800 active merchants and 18,000 monthly orders or monetised outcomes. Expansion should use replicated cells, not national blanket coverage.

A new city requires:

- local operations owner;
- anchor merchant cohort;
- catalogue coverage;
- PSP and settlement continuity;
- two fulfilment routes;
- return and pickup plan;
- 13-week local cash model;
- launch and stop criteria.

If transaction economics remain weak, the business should concentrate on the most defensible vertical—potentially power and building procurement—rather than continue as a broad marketplace.

85. KPI tree

The north-star metric should be **successfully completed customer outcomes with positive contribution**. It includes completed Buy Now orders, collected reservations and verified quote outcomes that meet the billing definition.

Supporting KPI groups are:

Demand

- qualified sessions;
- search success rate;
- product-to-action conversion;
- repeat buyer rate;
- owned demand share;
- customer acquisition cost.

Supply

- active transaction merchants;
- current offers;
- offer match rate;
- stock and price accuracy;
- activation time;
- merchant retention.

Transaction

- checkout conversion;
- payment success;
- seller acceptance;
- cancellation and substitution;
- on-time fulfilment;
- return and refund rate.

Trust

- complaints per 100 orders;
- median resolution time;
- fraud and chargeback loss;
- verified-review coverage;
- repeat purchase after a problem.

Economics

- GMV;
- net revenue;

- contribution per order;
- delivery contribution;
- support cost per order;
- merchant acquisition payback;
- cash runway.

86. Metric definitions that prevent self-deception

An **active merchant** has at least one current offer and has accepted an order, completed a quote response or refreshed qualifying inventory in the previous 30 days. A registered account is not active.

A **current offer** has valid seller, branch, product match, price or quote state, currency, fulfilment method and freshness within the category threshold.

A **completed order** has verified delivery or collection, passed the customer acceptance window and has no unresolved refund. A paid-but-rejected order is not completed.

A **verified quote outcome** requires a structured request, merchant response and buyer-confirmed progression. A click or WhatsApp open is not an outcome.

Net revenue excludes merchant payables, taxes collected for others and pure payment or courier pass-through amounts.

87. Experiment programme

Every major hypothesis should be tested through a named experiment.

Priority experiments are:

1. Will merchants maintain offers through one-tap confirmation?
2. Does pickup materially improve completion and margin versus home delivery?
3. Will buyers prepay unknown marketplace sellers when protection is clear?
4. Which fee structure creates the best merchant retention and contribution?
5. Does compatibility guidance improve conversion and reduce returns?
6. Do structured quote requests outperform WhatsApp lead handoff?
7. Can assisted onboarding fall below US$20 per activated merchant?
8. Does merchant-owned audience distribution produce repeat Shoppage demand?
9. Which diaspora categories have acceptable chargeback and fulfilment risk?
10. Can a second cell reproduce first-cell performance without founder intervention?

Each experiment has hypothesis, cohort, success threshold, guardrail, owner, duration and decision.

88. Kill criteria

The company should stop or materially pivot the broad marketplace model if, after six months of focused operation:

- seller acceptance remains below 85% despite enforcement;
- seller-caused cancellation remains above 10%;
- repeat purchase remains below 15% in eligible categories;
- variable support and fulfilment exceed gross transaction revenue;
- merchant activation cost cannot be recovered within six months;
- paid customer acquisition is required for most orders and payback exceeds 12 months;
- buyers consistently refuse prepaid transactions and pickup or protection does not improve conversion;
- rights or regulatory constraints prevent a workable public catalogue or settlement flow;
- the team cannot reconcile payments, refunds and merchant payouts reliably.

A pivot may focus Shoppage on procurement requests, vertical comparison, merchant software or a narrower managed-commerce category. Continuing because the database is large would be irrational.

89. Investor proof package

Before raising a major institutional round, Shoppage should be able to show:

- 12 months of cohort and transaction data;
- audited or independently reviewed GMV and revenue reconciliation;
- active merchant and offer definitions;
- order-level contribution by category and cell;
- repeat purchase and retention;
- seller performance distribution;
- customer complaint and refund evidence;
- legal and data-rights register;
- security assessment;
- credible city-replication playbook;
- evidence that first-party data improves conversion or merchant value.

The investor story is not “Zimbabwe has no Amazon.” It is: “We have built the operating layer that converts fragmented local supply into reliable commerce, and this cell can be repeated.”

Final verdict

Shoppage has a legitimate opportunity, but only if it abandons inflated breadth and proves the hard transaction layer. The strongest concept is not the fifth social icon, an 80-page list of moats or a million-product reference library. It is a disciplined shared-catalogue marketplace that makes local offers current, orders accountable, fulfilment visible and failure remediable.

The immediate mission is therefore narrow and severe:

> ***Within 90 days, prove that 15 to 25 Harare merchants can fulfil 200 real customer outcomes through Shoppage with accurate offers, complete reconciliation, at least 90% on-time fulfilment and known positive or improvable contribution economics.***

Pass that test and the national marketplace thesis becomes investable. Fail it and Shoppage must narrow the model before spending on plugins, video feeds, agencies, warehouses, fleets or national scale.

Appendix A - Binding decision register

The following decisions define v4.0. Any change requires a written decision record stating evidence, owner, date, expected metric impact and reversal condition.

Decision	Current position	Revisit trigger
Business model	Managed multi-vendor marketplace with four transaction lanes	Legal or economic evidence makes controlled transactions unworkable
Launch geography	Harare coverage cell, not national launch	First cell passes three months of contribution and SLA gates
Launch category	Power, tools and home improvement	Merchant interviews or pilot baskets show weak demand or margin
Inventory ownership	Merchant-held	Proven fast-moving cohort supports warehouse economics
Delivery	Merchant and partner fulfilled	Route density proves owned-fleet business case
Payments	Licensed PSP; no informal custody	Regulated marketplace settlement structure approved
Architecture	Modular monolith	Demonstrated scaling or security boundary requires separation
Public data	Claimed or rights-cleared records only	New source licence or merchant consent
AI	Assistive, no autonomous commercial claims	Evaluation passes and human-control risk falls
Merchant pricing	Free foundation plus one US$19 growth tier	Pilot willingness-to-pay and contribution evidence
Expansion	Cell-by-cell	Exit gates passed
Plugin marketplace	Deferred	Core integrations stable and third-party developer demand proven

Appendix B - Merchant onboarding SOP

B1. Intake

1. Record source of lead and category.
2. Confirm authorised representative and daily operator.
3. Explain transaction lanes, fees, settlement timing, returns and data use.
4. Select assisted, bulk or integrated onboarding lane.
5. Create merchant and branch records in prospect state.

B2. Evidence

Collect only what is required for the merchant's risk and legal structure:

- responsible-person identity and contact;
- business or trading evidence;
- physical or collection location;
- settlement account ownership;
- category-specific licences where relevant;
- return address and complaint contact;
- warranty and fulfilment policies.

Record evidence source, date, reviewer and expiry. Do not publish confidential documents.

B3. Contracting

The merchant accepts the marketplace agreement, fee schedule, prohibited-products policy, data-processing terms, seller SLAs, refund and set-off rights, and content licence. Any negotiated exception is written and approved.

B4. Catalogue readiness

1. Load initial product data.
2. Match to master products.
3. Resolve duplicates and missing attributes.
4. Confirm price, currency, stock state and fulfilment.
5. Review images and restricted claims.
6. Publish test-only offers.

B5. Operational readiness

- train order operator;
- test notification channels;
- confirm acknowledgement method;
- test pickup or courier handoff;

- test cancellation and refund;
- confirm support escalation;
- complete one successful test order.

B6. Activation

Operations approves readiness score and opens permitted transaction lanes. Merchant receives launch checklist, QR or share links and first-week review schedule.

B7. First-30-day monitoring

Review every order, rejection, substitution, late event and complaint. New merchants may have shorter settlement cycles only after sufficient clean outcomes. At-risk merchants receive remediation or pause.

Appendix C - Category readiness checklist

A category is not launch-ready until the following are defined:

1. buyer job and product decision logic;
2. master-product attributes and variant rules;
3. common local terms and units;
4. eligible transaction lane;
5. stock and price freshness threshold;
6. delivery or pickup constraints;
7. seller evidence requirements;
8. warranty and return rules;
9. restricted claims and safety guidance;
10. typical payment and fraud risk;
11. unit-economics model;
12. at least three credible sellers or a justified specialist exception;
13. support decision tree;
14. test orders covering normal and failure paths.

The category owner signs readiness. Marketing cannot launch an incomplete category because traffic has been purchased.

Appendix D - Order and exception playbook

D1. Seller rejects paid order

- capture reason: no stock, price error, delivery constraint, suspected fraud or other;
- stop fulfilment and notify customer immediately;
- offer comparable alternative only with customer approval;
- initiate refund under PSP process;
- record seller incident and offer accuracy impact;
- escalate repeated rejection to pause.

D2. Partial acceptance

- split accepted and rejected lines;
- recalculate delivery and fees;
- require customer approval before proceeding;
- refund rejected value;
- preserve original order and adjustment history.

D3. Customer unavailable

- carrier records attempt and evidence;
- contact customer through approved channels;
- apply published re-delivery or pickup option;
- do not mark completed without receipt evidence.

D4. Wrong or damaged item

- open case with photos and packaging evidence;
- determine seller, packing or carrier responsibility;
- provide replacement, return or refund under policy;
- update product, seller or courier root cause.

D5. Suspected account takeover

- freeze high-risk changes and payouts;
- invalidate sessions;
- contact known merchant owner through independent channel;
- preserve logs;
- escalate to security and privacy owner.

D6. Payment received without order record

- search by PSP reference, customer and amount;
- create finance exception, not a manual completed order;

- verify source notification and bank movement;
- refund or reconstruct only under dual approval.

Appendix E - Return and refund responsibility matrix

Cause	Primary responsibility	Normal remedy
Seller has no stock after acceptance	Seller	Full refund; seller incident
Wrong product supplied	Seller	Replacement or full refund including reasonable return cost
Product materially misdescribed	Seller	Return and refund
Transit damage under platform courier	As contracted with carrier; customer protected operationally	Replacement or refund; recover from responsible party
Customer changes mind where policy allows	Customer subject to law and terms	Return less permitted direct cost
Compatibility advice from merchant is wrong	Merchant unless platform made the representation	Remedy and root-cause review
Platform catalogue mismatch caused error	Shoppage and seller coordination	Customer remedy; catalogue correction
Custom product correctly supplied	Policy and law	Usually restricted return unless defective
Installation misuse	Evidence-based	Warranty or paid remedy as applicable

This matrix requires legal review and category-specific schedules before publication.

Appendix F - Trust-evidence dictionary

Listed record: derived from a documented source; not merchant-controlled and not a current-offer claim.

Claimed business: an authorised representative controls the page.

Identity checked: responsible person and contact evidence reviewed.

Location checked: current trading or collection location corroborated.

Trading evidence checked: recent products, invoices, supplier or physical evidence reviewed under policy.

Current offer: price or quote state, currency, branch, fulfilment and freshness valid.

Proven fulfilment: minimum transaction count achieved with acceptable cancellation, delivery and complaint rate.

Verified purchase review: linked to a completed platform order.

Merchant-provided warranty: warranty is the seller or manufacturer’s promise, not Shoppage’s guarantee.

Platform protection eligible: order falls within the published payment, category, delivery and evidence rules.

Appendix G - Data rights register template

For every source, record:

- source name and owner;
- acquisition date and method;
- contract, licence or legal basis;
- original file or endpoint;
- permitted internal use;
- permitted public fields;
- permitted derived and aggregate use;
- AI retrieval or training permission;
- personal-data classification;
- image, logo and trademark status;
- retention and refresh rule;
- correction and suppression contact;
- owner and approval date;
- status: blocked, internal only, public limited or public approved.

No engineer or marketer may override a blocked source because it is technically convenient.

Appendix H - KPI dictionary

H1. Supply metrics

Qualified merchant prospect: meets category, location and trading-evidence criteria and has an accountable contact.

Activation rate: merchants reaching transaction-live divided by contracted merchants in the cohort.

Median activation time: elapsed business days from complete evidence to transaction-live, excluding documented merchant delay.

Offer match rate: imported seller rows matched to an approved master product without manual master creation.

Current-offer rate: current live offers divided by all published seller offers.

Stock accuracy: accepted order lines available as represented divided by lines ordered from “in stock” offers.

H2. Demand metrics

Search success: searches resulting in a suitable current offer or structured request, excluding bot traffic.

Qualified session: human session with a product, category, merchant or request interaction meeting analytics rules.

Product-action conversion: sessions viewing an eligible product that initiate Buy Now, reserve or quote.

Owned demand share: qualified sessions originating from direct, organic, saved, notification, QR, referral or merchant-owned sources divided by all qualified sessions.

H3. Transaction metrics

Payment success: verified successful payments divided by valid payment attempts.

Seller acceptance: seller sub-orders accepted divided by paid or committed sub-orders presented to sellers.

Seller-caused cancellation: accepted or presented orders cancelled because of seller stock, price, response or fulfilment failure divided by eligible orders.

On-time fulfilment: deliveries or pickups ready within the promised window divided by completed fulfilments.

Completion rate: orders delivered or collected and outside the acceptance window without unresolved case divided by created paid orders.

H4. Economics metrics

GMV: merchandise value of completed orders, excluding cancelled and refunded value and excluding pure delivery where separately stated.

Net transaction revenue: platform transaction fee after contractual reversals; report PSP cost separately unless the business model treats it as net agency revenue.

Contribution per order: defined in Section 62 and calculated consistently.

Merchant acquisition cost: direct sales, field, onboarding and allocated campaign cost divided by activated transaction merchants.

Merchant payback: acquisition cost divided by monthly merchant contribution.

Customer acquisition payback: paid acquisition cost divided by monthly contribution from the acquired cohort.

Appendix I - Financial assumptions register

The base model should contain editable assumptions, not hard-coded optimism.

Demand assumptions

- monthly qualified sessions;
- conversion by transaction lane;
- average order or quote value;
- repeat purchase;
- cancellation, return and refund;
- paid versus owned acquisition mix.

Supply assumptions

- merchant prospects and activation rate;
- active-offer count per merchant;
- offer freshness;
- seller acceptance;
- merchant churn;
- paid-tier conversion.

Revenue assumptions

- fee by category and lane;
- subscription price and discounts;
- promotion take-up;
- delivery margin;
- managed-service revenue;
- refund and reversal treatment.

Cost assumptions

- PSP method mix and fee;
- courier subsidy and failed-delivery rate;
- support minutes and labour cost;
- onboarding cost;
- hosting, messaging and AI unit cost;
- fraud, chargeback and goodwill provision;
- payroll, legal, security and office costs.

Working-capital assumptions

- PSP settlement days;
- merchant payout days;

- refund timing;
- reserves;
- tax payment cycle;
- prepaid annual software and contract commitments.

Every monthly review should compare actual to assumption and identify which variance changed cash runway.

Appendix J - Detailed risk register

J1. Marketplace liquidity risk

Risk: insufficient quality supply and demand in the same cell and category.

Mitigation: anchor merchants, narrow cells, merchant audience distribution, request network and category depth before expansion.

Contingency: concentrate on procurement or a single vertical.

J2. Informal-merchant compliance risk

Risk: the platform unintentionally represents tax, registration, warranty or product status that the merchant cannot support.

Mitigation: evidence-specific labels, seller of record disclosure, restricted categories and progressive transaction eligibility.

Contingency: quote or pickup-only lane, or seller suspension.

J3. Marketplace fraud

Risk: fake sellers, stolen identities, payment diversion, collusive orders or fraudulent refunds.

Mitigation: identity evidence, independent callbacks, event logs, risk scoring, payout holds, device and payment controls.

Contingency: freeze accounts, preserve evidence, notify PSP and authorities where required.

J4. Legal classification risk

Risk: Shoppage's actual conduct makes it principal seller, payment intermediary or regulated operator despite contractual labels.

Mitigation: legal design review, operational alignment, licensed partners and periodic audit.

Contingency: change transaction flow, contract or product scope.

J5. Technology execution risk

Risk: over-customisation of the commerce framework creates fragile software.

Mitigation: modular domain boundaries, automated tests, limited launch scope and senior code review.

Contingency: disable non-core module and preserve manual operations.

J6. Founder-dependence risk

Risk: merchant relationships, approvals and operational knowledge remain with one person.

Mitigation: CRM, SOPs, role ownership, audit trail and delegated approval.

Contingency: reduce expansion until second-line leadership is functional.

J7. Capital risk

Risk: the business reaches a partial product but not transaction density before funding is exhausted.

Mitigation: 13-week cash forecast, stage gates, founder-led sales, variable field resources and no asset-heavy expansion.

Contingency: vertical pivot, service revenue or controlled pause.

Appendix K - RACI for launch-critical processes

R = responsible, A = accountable, C = consulted, I = informed.

Process	A / R	C / I
Cell selection	CEO / Operations lead	Product, finance, merchant agents
Merchant approval	Operations lead / Activation agent	Legal, finance, catalogue
Catalogue master change	Catalogue lead / Reviewer	Category expert, merchant
Payment release	Finance owner / Finance operator	Operations, PSP
Refund approval	Operations lead / Support	Finance, merchant
High-risk seller suspension	Trust owner / Investigator	Legal, operations, CEO
Product deployment	Technical lead / Engineer	Product, security, operations
Data breach response	DPO / Security lead	CEO, legal, technical
Public launch decision	CEO / Product and operations leads	Board, legal, finance, security

Appendix L - Merchant agreement commercial checklist

The final agreement should address:

1. appointment and legal role;
2. seller of record and contract formation;
3. merchant eligibility and evidence;
4. product accuracy and restricted goods;
5. price, currency, tax and invoicing;
6. stock and fulfilment commitments;
7. payment, fees and settlement;
8. reserves, set-off and chargebacks;
9. cancellation, returns, refunds and warranties;
10. delivery and risk transfer;
11. customer data and marketing limits;
12. content licence and intellectual property;
13. platform ranking and sponsorship disclosure;
14. complaints, audits and records;
15. suspension and termination;
16. liability, indemnity and insurance where appropriate;
17. dispute resolution and governing law;
18. data export and post-termination obligations.

Appendix M - Product backlog by release

Release 0: operating prototype

- merchant and branch records;
- master product and seller offer;
- assisted and CSV import;
- search and product page;
- Buy Now single seller;
- reservation and quote;
- PSP payment status;
- seller acknowledgement;
- pickup and manual delivery events;
- operations queues;
- basic return and refund;
- reconciliation export and ledger.

Release 1: controlled public launch

- customer accounts and order history;
- courier adapter;
- trust evidence;
- support cases;
- promotion eligibility;
- saved items and alerts;
- merchant analytics;
- stronger fraud controls;
- automated settlement statements.

Release 2: cell growth

- multi-seller sub-orders;
- pickup network;
- enterprise feeds;
- compatibility bundles;
- installer accounts;
- diaspora recipient flow;
- group buy pilot;
- agency referral tools.

Deferred

- public developer marketplace;
- unrestricted national directory;
- owned wallet or lending;
- owned warehouse and fleet;
- behavioural recommendation feed;
- national short-video entertainment feed;
- automated creator outcome commission;
- open bulk intelligence API.

Appendix N - Source register and evidence hierarchy

The business plan uses three evidence classes.

Primary and regulatory sources

- Zimbabwe National Statistics Agency, 2025 Economic Census presentation and results.
- Reserve Bank of Zimbabwe, 2026 Monetary Policy Statement and applicable payment-system guidance.
- Postal and Telecommunications Regulatory Authority of Zimbabwe, Data Protection (Licensing of Data Controllers and Appointment of Data Protection Officers) Regulations, SI 155 of 2024.
- Consumer Protection Act [Chapter 14:44].
- Cyber and Data Protection Act [Chapter 12:07].
- Zimbabwe Revenue Authority guidance on VAT and digital services.
- Paynow developer documentation for supported payment methods and technical flows.
- Zimpost service information for national mail, courier and logistics infrastructure.

Primary-source links:

- ZIMSTAT Economic Census: https://www.zimstat.co.zw/wp-content/uploads/production/EconomicCensus/EC2025_PRESENTATION.pdf
- RBZ 2026 Monetary Policy Statement: https://www.rbz.co.zw/documents/mps/2026/MPS_FINAL_-_FULL.pdf
- Data Controller Licensing Regulations: https://www.potraz.gov.zw/wp-content/uploads/2025/02/sI-155-of-2024-Cyber-and-Data-Protection-Normal_240913_1250178.pdf
- Consumer Protection Act: https://www.veritaszim.net/sites/veritas_d/files/Consumer%20Protection%20Act.pdf
- Cyber and Data Protection Act: https://www.veritaszim.net/sites/veritas_d/files/Cyber%20%26%20Data%20Protection%20Act%20Cap1207%20No%205%20of%202021%20gaz%202022-03-11.pdf
- Paynow Express Checkout documentation: https://developers.paynow.co.zw/docs/paynow/express_checkout_transactions/
- Zimpost logistics services: https://www.zimpost.co.zw/services/mail-logistics

Platform and competitor sources

- Classifieds.co.zw public site and terms.
- Ownai public marketplace presence.
- ZimbabweMall public site.
- Merchant, courier and PSP interviews to be completed during the first 30 days.

Internal assets requiring rights review

- company and merchant prospect datasets;

- Facebook-group mapping;
- product and SKU reference files;
- market and location data;
- prior Shoppage research reports.

External statistics are context, not a substitute for field evidence. Where sources conflict, Shoppage should disclose the range and use conservative operating assumptions.

Appendix O - Management launch scorecard

The weekly launch scorecard should fit on one page and show:

Dimension	Primary measure	Gate status
Supply	Transaction-active merchants and current offers	Green, amber or red
Demand	Qualified sessions and action conversion	Green, amber or red
Order quality	Acceptance, cancellation and substitution	Green, amber or red
Fulfilment	On-time delivery or pickup and failed attempts	Green, amber or red
Trust	Complaints, refund clock and fraud loss	Green, amber or red
Economics	Contribution per order and cash runway	Green, amber or red
Controls	Reconciliation, security and data-rights exceptions	Green, amber or red

Each red metric requires an owner, action and decision date. A scorecard without decisions is reporting theatre.

Appendix P - Field interview guide

Merchant interviews should test behaviour, not solicit compliments about the idea.

Ask the merchant to show:

- how prices are set and changed;
- where stock is recorded;
- what happens when a WhatsApp customer orders an unavailable item;
- delivery pricing and failure handling;
- return and warranty examples;
- payment methods and settlement evidence;
- a real product list, invoice or recent order;
- who would operate Shoppage daily;
- what fee would be acceptable for a proven order;
- what would cause them to stop using the platform.

Buyer interviews should use a real shopping task. Ask the buyer to compare current methods, identify trust concerns, complete a prototype checkout and explain when they would prepay, reserve, collect or request a quote.

Appendix Q - Definition of done for the first investable cell

The first cell is investable when:

- at least 50 merchants are active and no single merchant dominates;
- at least 15,000 offers meet freshness rules;
- 1,000 or more monthly customer outcomes are completed;
- seller acceptance exceeds 95%;
- seller cancellation is below 5%;
- on-time fulfilment exceeds 90%;
- payment and settlement reconciliation has no unexplained material difference;
- contribution is positive before central product payroll;
- at least 25% of eligible customers repeat within 90 days;
- merchant activation payback is below six months;
- operations can run for two weeks without daily founder intervention;
- legal, privacy, security and rights controls have been independently reviewed.

This is the standard Shoppage must meet before claiming a repeatable national model.